MISSISSIPPI

The Magnolia State



The Mississippi River has always had a personality: wide, dark, and unhurried, carrying the silt and soil of half a continent southward toward the Gulf. It was that river mud, rich and deep chocolate brown, that gave this dessert its name. Like the river, it carries the story of the people who have lived along its banks.

The Delta's table was shaped long before this pie existed. Black cooks, enslaved and later free, built much of the region's culinary tradition in plantation kitchens, church halls, and home kitchens, and their skill with pecans, molasses, eggs, and chocolate set the standard for dense, deeply flavored sweets across the Mississippi Valley. Mississippi Mud Pie is a much younger dish, but it grew up in the food culture they helped create.

Its story begins with the river itself. Steamboats and rail lines made river towns like Vicksburg and Natchez, and ports like New Orleans, gateways for goods, and by the late 19th century chocolate was no longer a luxury. Over the 20th century, the pantry changed. Chocolate cookies became a favorite way to make a crust without an oven. By the 1950s, electric refrigerators and freezers were standard in American kitchens, and cooks could set a dessert rather than bake it. Instant puddings and whipped toppings soon followed.

The name "Mississippi Mud" appears in American newspaper recipe columns by the 1960s, first on a rich chocolate cake and, by the early 1970s, on the chilled pie. Where it began is still debated, and several towns have claimed it, but the inspiration is clear: the dark, silky look of the riverbank mud that lines the Mississippi on a drying August afternoon in Greenville or Clarksdale. The comparison stuck because anyone who has stood on that bank and looked down at the dark, smooth earth understands what they are about to taste.

This is a dessert that rewards you generously. A crisp chocolate cookie crust holds a cool, fudgy chocolate filling, topped with cream and chocolate shavings or toasted pecans. Slice it straight from the refrigerator or freezer, with a dollop of whipped cream or a spoonful of vanilla ice cream melting alongside, and you won't just be making dessert. You'll be sitting down at a table with generations of Southern cooks and one of its most beloved sweets.

MISSISSIPPI MUD PIE

A gloriously fudgy, crumbling-edged, pecan-studded slab of Southern joy that turns any ordinary table into a celebration.

Yield: 10–12 servings

INGREDIENTS

CRUST

- 2 cups chocolate wafer cookies or chocolate graham crackers, finely crushed
- ½ cup unsalted butter, melted
- 2 Tbsp granulated sugar

FUDGE LAYER

- 1 cup semisweet chocolate chips
- ½ cup unsalted butter
- ¾ cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs, lightly beaten
- 2 Tbsp unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- ¼ tsp salt

CHOCOLATE PUDDING LAYER

- ½ cup granulated sugar
- ¼ cup cornstarch
- ¼ cup unsweetened cocoa powder
- ¼ tsp salt
- 2½ cups whole milk
- 3 large egg yolks, lightly beaten
- 4 oz. semisweet chocolate, chopped
- 2 Tbsp unsalted butter
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

WHIPPED CREAM TOPPING

- 1½ cups heavy cream, cold
- 3 Tbsp powdered sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Garnish (optional): chocolate curls, chopped toasted pecans, mini marshmallows, or chocolate sauce

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Make the crust*: Preheat oven to 350°F (175°C). Mix the crushed wafers, melted butter, and sugar until evenly moistened. Press into the bottom and sides of a 9-inch deep-dish pie pan. Bake for 8–10 minutes until set. Cool completely.
2. *Make the fudge layer*: In a saucepan over low heat, melt chocolate chips and butter, stirring until smooth. Whisk in sugar, then remove from heat and whisk in eggs quickly (so they don't scramble). Stir in cocoa, vanilla, and salt until glossy. Spread evenly over cooled crust. Bake 15 minutes at 350°F (175°C), until just set but slightly gooey in the center. Cool.
3. *Make the chocolate pudding layer*: In a saucepan, whisk sugar, cornstarch, cocoa, and salt. Slowly whisk in milk until smooth. Cook over medium heat, whisking constantly, until thickened and bubbling. Temper egg yolks by whisking in a little hot mixture, then return yolks to the pan. Cook 1 minute more. Remove from heat, stir in chopped chocolate, butter, and vanilla until smooth. Pour pudding over fudge layer. Cover with plastic wrap (touching surface to prevent skin) and chill at least 3 hours until firm.
4. *Make the whipped cream topping*: Beat cream, powdered sugar, and vanilla until soft peaks form. Spread generously over the chilled pie.
5. *Garnish and serve*: Top with chocolate curls, toasted pecans, or marshmallows if desired. Slice and serve chilled but not icy cold, so the layers soften slightly.

